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Section Title(S)

RECIPROCITY, REDISTRIBUTION AND THE MALE LIFE CYCLE: VARIATIONS IN MIDDLE RIVER TONGA SOCIAL ORGANIZATION • The network of relationships

RECIPROCITY, REDISTRIBUTION AND THE MALE LIFE CYCLE: VARIATIONS IN
MIDDLE RIVER TONGA SOCIAL ORGANIZATION *

by

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Material Not Relevant

IN 1958 the Kariba Dam was completed and rising Zambezi waters began a final inundation of the Gwembe Valley's narrow strip of fertile alluvial fields and gardens. The place these plots of ground had earned in the eyes of generations of Valley dwellers had become deeply imbedded in their way of life. A study of Gwembe Tonga social organization and adaptation to this old environment was carried out in 1956–7 by Drs E. Colson and T. Scudder (Colson, 1960; Scudder, 1962). In 1962 the same authors returned for another year to study the resettlement and its ramifications, and this article is an interpretation of the social organization on one particular group as it appeared then. Particular attention has been paid to Chezia neighbourhood and specific data have been drawn and cited from three of the hamlet clusters comprising the village of Jeremiah. Chezia lies within Chipepo Chieftaincy, in what has been called Middle River Region (Colson, 1960, 4). It is believed that the account presented here would have been a fair representation of 1962–3 Middle River social organization as a whole. In analysing the material summarized here it appeared that the organization and dynamics of this society could best be understood and described by tracing through characteristic activities and relations of males of various ages and statuses. This seemed particularly appropriate for a point in time when certain

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ecological and social guides for action in Valley life had been altered or moved.

The network of relationships

Middle River neighbourhoods have been important social units and typically include a number of villages. Within the neighbourhood each  140 man usually relates to the majority of other men by means of several different links of kinship and affinity. Middle River neighbourhoods like Chezia are not completely endogamous, however, nor as a general rule are Tonga social relations of any kind exclusively and sharply bounded by specific principles of locality as such. Valley polity, as a whole consists of an overlapping series of vicinages of neighbourhoods whose individual members meet frequently, for a variety of reasons and in numerous ways. Normal obligations of kinship and affinity, exigencies of periodic hunger, needs of trade and barter, the opportunities of wage labour, and numerous other factors cause people to do a good deal of travelling within and also beyond the valley. Within this extensive social field Middle River Tonga may regulate their interactions as coclansmen, kinsmen, members of neighbourhoods, in a clan-joking relationship, or, less commonly, as bond friends. Conduct of all these classes of relationship depends, at least in part, upon a kinship model. The Tonga have traditionally moved freely over the landscape, and the importance they attach to the various ties of kinship overrides the rather vague limits of Tonga neighbourhood and other spatial boundaries.

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* This article grew out of work begun in Dr E. Colson's graduate seminar at the University of California, Berkeley. The material has been drawn directly from the 1962-3 field notes of Drs T. Scudder and E. Colson, whose researches were financed by the Institute for Social Research in the University of Zambia. The author has also benefited greatly from lengthy discussions with Dr Colson. In the interests of personal privacy, names of individuals, hamlet clusters and villages have been changed.

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